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Living in Endtimes: Countersentimental Domesticity in the Age of Uncertainty

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ABSTRACT
The clashing crises of today's world are often lived in a state of impasse, trying to figure out how to respond and to adapt. The article argues that fiction can capture these contradictory affective atmospheres and to help the readers reflect on the crisis of the future. Specifically, the article will focus on domesticity, as a site in which acts of interpersonal care help readers not only imagine but also live with the end of the world. The article will use the theoretical apparatus built on the work of Lauren Berlant to read two novels that negotiate domesticity in the context of crisis ordinariness. Jenny Offill's *Weather* (2020) builds a meditation on the climate crisis, Clare Pollard's *Delphi* (2022) on the COVID-19 pandemic. In both cases, the novels allow the readers to experience stasis, but also the countersentimental interpersonal connection that makes the endtimes liveable.

Introduction

It has become commonplace to observe that in today's world crisis has become banalized and ordinary. Climate emergency, intensifying wars in different parts of the world, including Europe, and the rise of authoritarianism even in established democracies started a long time ago but the results of these slowly unfolding processes have become starkly visible only when it appears impossible to do anything to stop the seemingly fateful sequence of events. This leaves people in a state of anxiety about "what has not yet come" (Clough and Wise 2). Writing about "the sense of an ending," Frank Kermode alerts us to the human desire to make sense of our existence through fictions of beginnings and ends that both give "shape" to life and "endow the interval between them with meaning" (3, 190). At the time when the end is present, even if stretched out in a tantalizing fashion, time is not necessarily viewed as *kairos*, a critical turning point. It is, instead, useful to think of Kermode's under-utilized term, *aevum*, a sort of a fiction of time that calls attention to the "relation between the fictions by which we order our world and the increasing complexity of what we take to be the 'real' history of that world" (67). With this, he focuses on the affective experience of attentive intersubjective duration (for recent studies on this aspect of Kermode's work, see Fuery or Dowthwaite). This attention to felt time, I believe, is particularly useful to understand our present, non-apocalyptic sense of ending.

Much has been written about the political passivity and stasis that characterize these endless endtimes. Yet this period of uncertainty is also rendered liveable as "people find themselves developing skills for adjusting to newly proliferating pressures to scramble for modes of living on" (Berlant, *Cruel* 8). Everyday life continues even in crisis-inundated times. It is thus important not to limit the discussion of crisis ordinariness to precarity and threat, but also to extend it to how people make the everyday liveable through acts of care or attachment. In the words of Berlant (*Cruel* 10), crisis "is a process embedded in the ordinary that unfolds in stories about navigating what's overwhelming." Stories of navigating the everyday also open up novel ways of thinking about agency and relationality,

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in particular for appreciating the importance of affective infrastructures and the attendant emotional labor that render life liveable.

This article argues that fiction is able to capture the contradictory affective atmospheres that emerge when people scramble to find ways of living on in a context inimical to human thriving and to create a space for "feeling-with" (Felski 41) to help the readers reflect on the crisis of the future that they, too, are engulfed in. Following Marco Caracciolo (183), I believe that fiction can be helpful both on the textual and experiential level, "by inspiring an interpretive negotiation of uncertainty in audiences." I am particularly compelled by Caracciolo's claim that, by negotiating uncertainty in fiction, readers might arrive at a more complex understanding of today's world. At the time of nihilistic post-truth politics with its black-and-white narratives such a grasp of complexity is needed to both comprehend what is going on and to imagine alternatives. This is why embracing "the open-endedness of our future and being able to harness it creatively might prove essential – perhaps as important as practical survival skills" (Caracciolo 184).

While Caracciolo has generatively analyzed complex narratives that train readers in affective meaning-making, the same purpose can be achieved with more accessible texts that address a general reading public. Specifically, the article will focus on domesticity, as a site in which this "suspended agency" (Ngai 2) is translated into acts of interpersonal care through which we can not just imagine but also live with the end of the world. Perhaps counter-intuitively, the article argues, domestic fictions possess a critical potential for negotiating and interrogating the planetary perma-crisis, precisely due to their attention to what makes crisis survivable. Unlike Ramamurthy, I do not think that such texts reduce concern for climate emergency to a private emotional crisis of the privileged from the Global North. By looking at the perspective of an individual, however limited, we can also see the ways in which crises of different scales are experienced in a private life. The readers can enter into a dialog with such representations and expand them. Most importantly, the narratives attempt to jolt the readers out of their stasis.

The article will use the theoretical apparatus built on the work of Lauren Berlant to read two novels that negotiate domesticity in the context of crisis ordinariness. Jenny Offill's *Weather*[1] builds a meditation on the climate crisis, Clare Pollard's *Delphi* on the COVID-19 pandemic. In both cases, the novels allow the readers to experience the stasis in which characters "scramble for modes of living on" (Berlant, *Cruel* 8), but also the countersentimental interpersonal connection that makes the endtimes liveable.

Inhabiting the Ordinary as a Form of Lateral Agency

Life, even in the time of permacrisis, is experienced in the eventful but repetitive everyday in which the reproduction of life takes place, especially for women who are responsible for the emotional labor of maintaining a household. Often, care for the domestic routines is read as a sign of resignation and, especially, as the muting or even repression of female agency and desire. However, it is productive to remember that Berlant views impasse not just as a dead end but also a possibility: "a stretch of time in which one moves around with a sense that the world is at once intensely present and enigmatic" (Berlant, *Cruel* 4). This contradictory combination creates, in Sianne Ngai's words, "a feeling of confusion about what one is feeling" (14). This confusion suggests a lack of a predictable cultural narrative and hence also creates an opportunity for alternative modes of sense-making that are derived from the commonplace rhythms of the private sphere, its care work and emotional labor. Stewart (1, 3), too, stresses the potentials that everyday, "a scene of both liveness and exhaustion," has due to its affective atmospheres the significance of which "lies in the intensities they build and in what thoughts and feelings they make possible."

Domestic fictions provide a particularly compelling canvas for investigating the everyday and its ordinary affects because of their positioning within what can be called "the sentimental account of the social world as an affective space where people ought to be legitimated because they have feelings" (Berlant, *Female* 2). This affective space, in a simplified form, valorizes what is undervalued in society

at large and promises "an alleviation of what is hard to manage in the lived real – social antagonisms, exploitation, compromised intimacies, the attrition of life" (Berlant, *Female* 5). The conventional domestic fiction replaces the social world of conflict with an alternative realm in which, instead, the lifeworlds of women and their circulating affective rhythms are given serious consideration. The fictions might not challenge dominant social or family values but they call attention to what is generally overlooked in culture at large to this day, especially the burden and cost of reproductive and emotional labor. Even in the most conventional examples of the genre, though, there are instances of women's creative negotiation of and at times even challenges to norms of idealized domestic femininity or social conventions. It is important to add here that the domestic fictions I look at are not related to the re-romantization of domestic femininity as a monetisable cultural and political fantasy (especially manifest in social media through so-called tradwives and mompreneurs) (McRobbie; Orgad). I focus on fictional texts that show the lived reality of the domestic sphere, with its work and frictions, that call attention to the contradictory satisfactions and inconveniences related to the reproduction of life. These texts continue the critical exploration of the existential aspects of banal domesticity in novels like Don DeLillo's *White Noise* (1985) where the domestic is juxtaposed with the catastrophic. However, in the novels explored here, the focus is shifted to the female point of view and the ironic distance reduced, permitting both critique and feeling-with.

Berlant introduces the term "countersentimental" to describe narratives that refuse "to reproduce the sublimation of subaltern struggles into conventions of emotional satisfaction and redemptive fantasy" (*Female* 56), thereby also disrupting the expectation of consent to general feeling rules of a society that designate what and who deserves compassion. While traditional sentimental fictions do not challenge social hierarchies or provide support beyond compassion for suffering, countersentimental texts make visible the struggle behind the conventional narrative resolution of sentimental fiction and who or what it rewards. Such texts are "lacerated by ambivalence," as they "struggle with their own attachment to the promise of a sense of unconflictedness, intimacy, and collective belonging" (Berlant, *Female* 55). While sentimental texts elevate noble personal suffering and sacrifice over the need to work toward social change, countersentimental texts have the potential to "deprivatize politics" (Berlant, *Female* 55) by making visible the conflicts and inequalities that pervade sentimental fictions, as well as the tacit understanding that feeling for unjust suffering is all that is required of a reader. "Sentimentality, after all, is the only vehicle for social change that neither produces more pain nor requires much courage, unlike other revolutionary rhetorics" (Berlant, *Female* 66). The affective focus of sentimentalism is its great power; it is important to harness it for projects that chafe against the social status quo.

Such texts also are built on inconvenience as "the affective sense of the familiar friction of being in relation" (Berlant, *Inconvenience* 2). Inconvenience, in this understanding, is an everyday fact of living with other people and the necessary corrective to our illusion of independence. In Berlant's terminology, inconvenience is compared to attachment: "attachment, one might say, is what draws you out into the world; inconvenience is the adjustment from taking things in" (Berlant, *Inconvenience* 6). For Berlant, the need for this type of inconvenience is "inevitably a feature of the sensual ordinary of the world" and in this "profoundly life-shaping" (Berlant, *Inconvenience* x, 6). Such inconvenience is a precondition of knowledge and relationality, as inconvenience requires (inter)action. Domestic life is full of such inconveniences that reveal our (often unevenly divided) vulnerability and "affirmative brokenness" (Berlant, *Inconvenience* 171).

Berlant calls countersentimental texts "juxtapolitical" (Berlant, *Female* 3) because they avoid meaningful conflict, even if they come into contact with potentially political issues. Sentimental genres, even if they challenge the dominant feeling rules, create a sense of community, a shared affective experience that helps to "magnetize optimism about living and being connected to strangers" (Berlant, *Female* xi). This connection is sustaining to the members who can recognize in other people's experiences their own frustrations – but it crucially does not challenge social ideologies (Berlant, *Female* 12). The juxtapolitical, however, remains ambivalent. It provides "the fantasy of a better proximate world so close that one can experience it affectively without being able to live it objectively"

(Berlant, *Female* 31). The fantasy might not challenge norms, but it, as Berlant argues, can be made into an opening into some form of lateral agency.

Berlant terms "lateral agency" a mode of being that challenges the self-contained and self-controlling sovereign subjectivity that is normative in contemporary societies. Lateral agency, in contrast, is characterized by its "roundabout movement" and "floating sideways" (Berlant, *Cruel* 231, 116), disrupting the speed and goal-orientedness of everyday life. Weariness and detachment need not be signs of resignation but can, instead be read as "affective forms of engagement" with crisis ordinariness. According to Adan and Bateman (108), "with its spreading-out qualities, lateral agency can, and often does, create gaps in what otherwise seem to be ever-intensifying neoliberal demands on, and of, labor and life," helping people in the process of "getting by, and living on" (Berlant, *Cruel* 99).

For Adan and Bateman (111), "precarity necessitates both a poetics and a politics of humble experimentation, creative unfolding, and undirected blundering about, and the effects of this experimentation [. . .] may not conform to more familiar understandings of either poetics or politics." They use the term "lateral aesthetics" for this type of creative practice. It can "insert – or better, insinuate – into their conditions and surroundings pauses that, no matter how subtle, deflationary, or provisional, call forth different, and at times quite radical, capacities of and for existence" (Adan and Bateman 109). This type of lateral aesthetics, I argue, can be seen in the domestic fictions that show how crisis ordinariness is being experienced, by demonstrating how the domestic is crucially impacted by the social world outside, with its violence and inequalities, and how it also provides relational resources for living on. I am particularly interested in the pauses that are created in the domestic fictions with the help of humor that permit both a form of juxtapolitical critique of the society outside the home and create a space, even if momentarily, for imagining forms of living otherwise. As Berlant reminds us, "in the intensified everyday there are always pointers to alternative experiences, even the yet unlived" (Berlant, *Female* 273). It is these pauses that can perhaps jolt us out of the crisis of the future by thinking about how to live better today.

Weathering the Endtimes

Offill's novel is at once a novel about family and about a slowly unfolding apocalypse. Already the title of the novel is telling, by evoking the climate emergency, the daily inevitability and unpredictability of weather and the internal weathering of storms. Dana Luciano titles her analysis of the novel with a quote from the novel, "of course, the world continues to end," and this indeed is a refrain that runs throughout the novel, not as an expression of climate grief but a stoic recognition of crisis ordinariness in which the climate emergency is but one component. Luciano (n.p.) calls the novel an example of depressive realism and describes it as being "uncomfortably numb." De Cristofaro draws attention to sleeplessness that recurs throughout the novel as a sign of eco-anxiety. My reading is different. To me the novel shows how the drumbeat of dread can be and is quelled by the need of living on. The end of the world is just another inconvenience – and perhaps not the most pressing one – that needs to be negotiated by Lizzie, the protagonist of the novel.

Lizzie, who has failed to complete her PhD, starts the novel working at a library while raising her son Eli with her husband Ben, a Classics PhD who now designs educational computer games. She is also taking care of her brother, a recovering addict embarking on fatherhood, and worrying about how she will be able to get her mother's teeth fixed (the narrator acerbically comments, "America is the name of this place where you can win big," after describing the lottery system at the dental clinic (Offill 172)). The couple make do, but barely. Lizzie is then offered a job by her former supervisor, Sylvia, who runs a podcast on climate change called *Hell and High Water*, to help her answer her e-mails.

The novel lacks a meaningful plot and instead evolves in six chapters, each consisting of short fragments of first-person narrative, interspersed with boxes that cite the various e-mails that Lizzie answers. The short fragments which capture a memory, experience, or encounter have affective intensity, although the effect often comes from ironic juxtaposition and the use of deadpan style

that underplays emotions. The style forces the reader to find or to create patterns between the events and musings, without imposing a plot or an interpretation.

The narrator is constantly aware of crisis ordinariness and the looming question is not whether we are inhabiting the endtimes, but rather how close we are to the actual ending. After reading some articles on disaster psychology she arrives at the following observation: "Much of the population was in a mild stupor, depressed, congregating in small unstable groups, and prone to rumors of doom. But I don't know. That's pretty much every day here." (Offill 124) The daily grind has created a pre-traumatic stress which does not permit people to take in additional anxiety without ceasing to function. They must continue to make a living and hence they learn to live with the anxiety, even if not very well.

Lizzie's new job exposes her to a stream of questions from listeners that show a wide range of anxieties, ranging from deranged ("Do angels need sleep?") or philosophical ("What is the philosophy of late capitalism?") to practical ("What are the best ways to prepare my children for the coming chaos?") (Offill 112, 44, 93). These queries are placed into text boxes that are surrounded by Lizzie's meandering commentary on daily life. The first Trump election happens in the second half of the novel (although Trump is not mentioned by name and there are no explicit comments on world affairs that would permit the clear placement of the text in time or even space). It is recorded as follows: "After the election, Ben makes many small wooden things. One to organize our utensils, one to keep the trash can from wobbling. He spends hours on them. 'There, I fixed it,' he says." (Offill 111). The desire to gain some control by fixing a minor domestic glitch in a world that seems to be careening to an end can be read as an example of lateral agency. Ben's other, perhaps more effective, remedy is to read the Stoics at breakfast. The only other commentary on the impending sense of social breakdown comes through another question from a podcast listener:

> Q: How can I tell if those around me would become good Germans?
>
> A: There is a historian named Timothy Snyder who has studied in great detail how past societies have descended into fascism. In his book *On Tyranny*, he made the following suggestions:
>
> *Make eye contact and small talk. This is not just polite. It is a way to stay in touch with your surroundings, break down unnecessary social barriers, and come to understand whom you should and should not trust. If we enter a culture of denunciation, you will want to know the psychological landscape of your daily life* (Offill 117, italics in the original)

The affective effect of the novel derives from the constant movement through the dread-inducing present that seems to be devoid of positive future scenarios and the recording of domestic routines that revolve around mundane acts of care. This contrast between the lived world and the imaginary worlds that the characters retreat to is shown throughout the novel. For some, the imaginary world is that of religion, for some prepping and for some just addiction. The fact that the world continues to end does not mean that we can or should let go of the everyday acts of care. It need not take much to generate at least some life-giving energy:

> When I get home, the dog wants an ice cube. I give her one, but she keeps banging her bowl around the kitchen. "How was your day?" I ask Ben. He shrugs. "I coded mostly, did some laundry."
>
> There is a heroic tower of folded things on the table. I spot my favorite shirt, my least depressing underwear. I go into the bedroom and change into them. Now I am a brand-new person. (Offill 13)

At the beginning of the novel, Sylvia attempts to reach out to tech billionaires, but gradually she, too, comes to the understanding that "there is not hope anymore, only witness" (Offill 133). She withdraws into the desert (the novel informs us that this practice was called *anachoresis* in Greek (Offill 140)). By the end of the novel, when Sylvia states that "of course, the world continues to end," she still goes out to water her garden (Offill 198). Lizzie, in contrast, gets something from her dentist to help her not grind her teeth when she sleeps (Offill 201). The answer to yet another question to how to maintain optimism is: "If you are not getting enough iron, put a few iron nails into a bowl of lemon juice and

leave it overnight. In the morning make lemonade out of it." (Offill 186). These quasi-ironic coping suggestions are interspersed with references to mystical texts. For example, she cites the monks at Mount Athos who respond to the question of what they do all day: "*We have died and we are in love with everything*." (Offill 200) Prepping for the end, the novel seems to suggest, does not necessarily mean piling up supplies but, rather, spiritual and sentimental education. Focusing on the daily exercise of living can also be read as an act of care.

Care work, with its many layers of inconvenience, is the source of meaning and connection in the novel. Offill provides a portrait of the ordinary rhythms of married life with its habitual intimacies (folding laundry, catching mice who seem to be a constant presence in the couple's life). The warmth of the marriage (although Lizzie has a brief fling) makes the hectic and unpredictable pace of care work bearable. In addition to her nuclear family, Lizzie takes care of her brother, a former addict, who has become a father and the arrival of the new baby adds more actual and emotional labor, as Henry becomes obsessed with the harms that might happen to the child. At the beginning of the novel, she is also extending her support to an adjunct she suspects of selling his plasma to make do and even the woman who comes to the library to steal toilet paper.

Lizzie's domestic world is surrounded not just by the privileged, even if not rich, people who write in to the podcast and the hum of the city around her (the action seems to take place in Brooklyn, so precarity also needs to be interpreted in this context). Lizzie overhears the following conversation: "It is important to be alert for 'the decisive moment,' says the man next to me who it talking to his date. I agree. The only difference is that is talking about twentieth-century photography and I am talking about twenty-first-century everything." (Offill 159) The coming of the end is treated calmly, with responses to questions about how to prepare children "for the upcoming chaos": "You can teach them to sew, to farm, to build. Techniques for calming a fearful mind might be the most useful though." (Offill 93)

This silent dialog with the world gives us an insight into crisis ordinariness that is all too recognizable. It is this dialog and the attendant introspection that give the novel its juxtapolitical character. Lizzie is not too numbed by depression to be unable to act and interact. She, for example, gives up using a car service when she understands the Islamophobia of the driver whom she had previously tried to support with her business. Lizzie, despite her increasing descent into anxiety and climate prepping wormholes on the Internet continues to be sustained by people around her who at times wear her out, but who also support her: her husband, brother, son, Sylvia, colleagues and even old friends who fix extra-strong drinks at the bar when she needs it.

Following Lizzie's life, the readers, too, get a heightened sense that we, like her, are at the same time inhabiting different scales of experience (this observation is also made by Leslie Jamison in her *New York Times* review). Some, like climate emergency, we cannot control, but many others we are still in charge of or at least can make a difference at. We can calm a crying child, but we can also extend out to others beyond our intimate family circle. The world's end does not give us an excuse to tune out or completely shut ourselves off from the world. It is helpful here to recall the reference to Timothy Snyder that Lizzie has given in one of her e-mail responses. The psychological landscape of our daily lives depends on knowing our neighbors and recognizing them as our neighbors even if they do not agree with our worldview. The private world, thus, is not represented as a space of escape and an excuse to surrender responsibility for the world at large. The scales are not equated, even if they are inhabited at the same time and with the same intensity. Sylvia has the luxury to retreat to the New Mexico desert and to water her garden. Lizzie's world is too precarious for such an escape and this very vulnerability forces her into a more juxtapolitical position. We see Lizzie's worrying but also get that this is not a solution.

Yet the novel does not propose an easy social solution. When Lizzie and Ben go to a meeting about social justice at the local Unitarian church, she sees well-intentioned people but cannot help being embarrassed (Offill 137). The same way, she will not give up her ham sandwich (Offill 16), although she understands that vegetarianism would greatly reduce the destruction of the planet. Insomnia is something that, in the circle of people like Lizzie, has come to be seen as a sign of one's appropriate

attitude. Such vacuous empathy also is an alibi for inaction and the novel makes the readers recognize this fact. This, too, is another mode of inhabiting the endtimes. The novel does not give us a cloying redemptive call for action. Instead, the desire to think that there is something that can get humans out of the mess is treated ironically by Sylvia who is irritated by having to append an "obligatory note of hope" (Offill 67). Sylvia's advice to Lizzie for protecting her family from the coming cataclysms is to "become rich, very very rich" (Offill 127). By stating the obvious, she reminds us that while practical tips (such as how to make a makeshift lamp out of a can of tuna (Offill 148)) are calming, they are not going to avert the disaster and that only tech billionaires have the luxury of imagining an escape, either through some technological fix or flight.

Perhaps most usefully, Offill allows us to experience Lizzie's internal struggles and introspection but does not drown out the awareness that around her there are others, with as complex – but different – interior worlds. Even in its first-person focus, the novel zooms in on relationality and intersubjectivity. The novel ends with the following scene:

> My husband is under the covers reading a long book about an ancient war. He turns out the light, arranges the blankets so we'll stay warm. The dog twitches her paws softly against the bed. Dreams of running, of other animals. I wake to the sound of gunshots. Walnuts on the roof, Ben says. The core delusion is that I am here and you are there. (Offill 201)

Caracciolo (187) notes that "The indeterminacy of the second-person pronoun ('you are there') complicates the ambiguity even further: at one level, the addressee could be Lizzie's husband, who is next to her in bed; however, given that this is the novel's final sentence – the place where the text opens onto the real world – the reader also becomes implicated in the 'you'." The text, thus, hints at not just the sustaining intimacy within the family but also with the readers. This intimacy, then, is also one of the rays of hope that the novel provides. We can perhaps no longer escape the end of the world but we can live the end better, by being mindful and practicing small acts of care and kindness to those around us. Lizzie's mother buys socks for the homeless and adds a dollar bill to each. This will not save the world, but will make one person's life more bearable, if only for a moment. In addition to practical advice that readers find all through the text, on the final page the author provides a link to https://www.obligatorynoteofhope.com/. (the link is still live at the time of writing this article) where the author gives some information about how to take action as "Aren't you tired of all this fear and dread?"

A Sense of an Ending

In Clare Pollard's *Deplhi* the disaster has more clearly defined contours, as its core narrative takes place during the COVID-19 pandemic. Unlike *Weather*, political figures and events (2020 US presidential elections, the January 6 insurgency, BLM protests) are mentioned to locate the text in a specific time and space. Yet, its novel covers the broader crisis ordinary existence of twenty-first-century life.

The first-person narrator again is an educated woman in a somewhat tired marriage and a sickly child. She has a part-time teaching job in Classics and makes additional income with translations. She is middle-class, although she does not like the label, because of its association with privilege (all they have is a flat and the ability to have vacations abroad and to order takeaway meals). The family life is stable enough, although the narrator has a brief and passionate fling with a colleague. She is aware of her relative invisibility as a middle-aged woman: "Now I'm in my mid-forties I don't suppose most people wonder what's in my head at all, or if they do they just think it's calories and flavored gin" (Pollard 113). The novel, though, proves otherwise, as the narrator thinks about the affective lifeworlds of domesticity, but also about current events and Classics. Her life is rote existence in today's unstable academic capitalism and the virus arrives in its world of attrition as almost a welcome surprise: "everyone is thrilled, actually! We are so bored of our unreal lives it is a change, at least; it is history happening." (Pollard 18). The narrator has a dream in which she, an "ordinary middle-aged woman," is selected as an oracle (Pollard 118) and the whole novel can, perhaps, be interpreted

as an attempt to describe the present that seems to be as incomprehensible in the novel as the future. The title certainly supports that interpretation.

Most of the novel takes place within the family home, with brief trips outside, but we do not meet any meaningful other characters beyond the small nuclear family. The narrator gets sick, as her son brings home the virus and this, in turn, infects the elderly family members of her husband one of whom ends up dying. This drama takes place outside the narrative frame and hence the focus of the novel remains on the narrator's detached musings. Death and tragedy are feared but not experienced. The text is written in a fragmentary style, like Offill's, but here the everyday narration is broken into manifold references to classical modes of divination and copious references to popular culture. Nothing seems to happen, while momentous things happen: "I can't even, to be honest, comprehend the numbers any more: 300 deaths a day, 400, 500. In a country of 63 million people is that utterly horrifying or nothing at all? Perhaps it's both, it feels like both." (Pollard 145)

The narrator researches modes of divination (e.g., prophecy by entrails, mirrors, or blood, in addition to the more conventional tarot cards or psychic readings). In the context of the crisis of the future, seeking to know what is yet to come takes on a different inflection. The novel begins with an epigraph from Anne Carson, "Kassandra: [scream] [scream] [scream] [scream]." The narrator's prophecies, like those of Cassandra, remain unheeded and her scream unspoken. Unlike Lizzie who scrolls the Internet in search of answers about how to survive the coming calamity, the unnamed narrator declares at the opening of the novel that "I am sick of the future. Up to here with the future." (Pollard 1). She has the overwhelming sense that today's world is saturated with too much future:

> We have to live with this rising tide of future, leaking and sopping over everything, claiming cities and sectors, until we're in the future, already—that dystopian future of surveillance, video calls and VR headsets, and viral epidemics spread by globalization, and the 24-news saying AI extinction event gene-modification the collapse of civilization (Pollard 1)

The breathless list ends with no punctuation as if the predictions of the many ends that seem to await humanity overwhelm the narrator. This device is used throughout the novel, but sparingly, so the phrases that peter out, without reaching the fixed form of a grammatically correct sentence, call attention to themselves and force the reader to catch a breath. They are often reserved to domestic minutiae: "In bed by night with a cup of weak herbal tea, bored, whilst Jason watches TV downstairs and probably gets the vodka out or has a sneaky joint or something like I'm his fucking headmistress" (Pollard 118).

In this novel, the reality is not encroaching on the life of the family as persistently as in Lizzie's case. They are insulated by money and by a smaller circle of relationality. Indeed, a lot of the family's reality is experienced vicariously, through screens. The narrator develops a theory about the Internet as a means to fill the void left by the death of God:

> For centuries humanity always felt being watched, and this knowledge gave even our smallest actions a sense of importance. Then, for a while, no one was bearing witness. No one was looking and it made us feel trivial and tenuous; utterly disposable to the indifferent world. That's why we wanted to be on reality TV, so someone would see us. And now social media has filled the void. No evil tweet, it promises, will go unread and unpunished; goodness will be rewarded with "likes" and supportive Mandela quotes, or photos of cats. Our whole lives will be archived and remembered—it is always looking, watching, tracking. Saving us. (Pollard 22)

Indeed, there are many comments on social media and its effect, as well as suggestions on how any fictional work – like the novel we are actually reading – cannot possibly capture the sheer amount of time spent removed from reality through TV, news, video games. During the pandemic, this hyper-connectivity becomes surreal, as "everything that wasn't TV is TV now too" as people "live more than six hours a day in fake worlds in which you can't touch or smell or intervene" (Pollard 30). Pollard is acerbic about the attention economy and its preying on people's reality hunger, as even potential acts of attentiveness and relationality with the world are turned into yet more social capital generating content (Pollard 33). The narrator is as scathing about herself:

> It amazes me how, even though I've read all 705 pages of Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* and was completely convinced by it, when Twitter nudges me towards some opinion piece on Trump on some news site, I can't consent to all the cookies quickly enough. Take all the data you want so long as you get that box of text out of my way. That is how the world ends, isn't it?" (Pollard 71)

The novel can be read in the countersentimental mode, as the narrator admits on page 1 that "something can be melodramatic and true at the same time" (Pollard 1). The family routines are recognizably unglamorous, starting from panic-buying (Pollard 18) to family meals which involve "always scraping pasta off the bottom of a pan" (Pollard 20). The narrator observes that "lots of people are finding out they don't really like their flats or marriages or lives that much." (Pollard 36). This leads her to a longer reflection on her own routines: "Home. The sameness of it. The word no longer cozy, a place to return to, but a word that has you caught like a maw. Drawing the curtains and opening the curtains. Changing the sheets. The dust on the grey sofas. The crumbs on the tiles. The damp Victorian walls." (Pollard 37) This home, unlike Lizzie's, does not become a site of marital relationality and domestic labor gets less attention than the shows they are watching. This leads to Jason, the narrator's husband, to ask "How are we at home more but do less cleaning?" (Pollard 29).

The domestic dialogs are abrasively complex, as the partners have developed a working relationship, but one that has come to terms with a lot of inconvenience and lacks frisson or even mutual support:

> I'm not paying much attention to Jason. He is an adult, he can sort out himself. Jason is also, of course, male, white, straight, middle class, able-bodied and cis, and as a society, we've recently been given a pass on thinking about the inner lives of such people. It has been a while since I've exerted myself to imagine his inner life. (Pollard 40)

The novel, though, provides many scenes of closeness, even if alcohol-fueled, during the lockdown that suggest that Jason is not so much ignored as taken for granted (the narrator dismisses the idea that he might be having an affair) and their many frictions are signs of an attachment that does not require much verbal reinforcement. Yet this flow of days that resemble each other in their predictability also hide references to actual domestic violence, even if not in the narrator's home, as a couple the narrator and her husband know have a physical fight during a Zoom call.

The relation that the narrator works on heavily is with her son. Interestingly, care work creates several conflicts with her beliefs: she kills a bee because of her son's allergies, despite the endangered nature of bees; buys apples in a plastic bag because of the price and allows Xander to have too much bacon. Parenting in this novel, unlike in *Weather*, is full of moral compromises that the narrator constantly ironically analyses, aware of the middle-class standards of contemporary mothering and the many ways in which they are created by those with the privilege to worry about each consumer choice. The punctuation also falters in some of these instances, suggesting the numbing rhythms of care work:

> Every day I set up Xander at the computer, make him something to eat, try to work, help him with his assignment, buy something online, make him something to eat, wash up, try to work, phone my mum, make us something to eat, work in front of the TV. *A Perfect Plant*, *It's a Sin*, *The Dig*, *Call My Agent*, *The Serpent*, *Can't Get You Out of My Head*. (Pollard 174)

Similar scenes of parenting during the pandemic recur in different sections of the novel, with regard to actual care work or online work: "I doesn't help that his fucking useless school barely does anything, just sends worksheets with things like word searches on them, but our printer is broken before I start my own work I have to write out all these fucking word searches by hand." (Pollard 20) The narrator indeed has hard time focusing on her work as both Jason and Xander have the priority right to use the home's office facilities.

Delphi, thus, is interestingly more intensely set in the historical present, with its many political and popular culture references that are lacking in *Weather*. Yet it is also more emphatically removed from social action. Lizzie feels that social action is an empty gesture that has lost is meaningfulness, but she engages with others outside of the immediate family circle all through the text. Even her e-mail answers provide a sort of a dialog. *Deplhi* is more firmly monologic,

punctured by copious references to different means of divination and Greek legends. These, however, lack any reciprocity and only lock the narrator within her own feverish imagination that obsesses, first and foremost, about her vulnerable son's health and possible future. She thinks about charity work outside of the home but never acts on the impulse (Pollard 134). At the end of the novel, indeed, the family unit retreats more deeply into itself, as Xander has a health crisis that a least temporarily brings the spouses together. Although the lockdown has ended, the novel closes in a tightly closed room, retreated from reality into more myth. The novel has toyed with countersentimental techniques, with its barbs at the political scene, but finally it adheres to the sentimental compact, in which the familial tragedy consumes our readerly attention and does not push us toward a deeper reflection on relationality as a form of juxtapolitical lateral agency. Yet it, still, manages to both represent and critique the ways in which domesticity is inhabited in the crisis ordinary times and shows the affective array of domestic inconvenience. The ambivalent potential of domestic fiction is thus still present in this text as well.

Conclusion

Lauren Berlant (*Inconvenience* 2) suggests that the observation that "'Hell is other people' has become a consoling thought" because of the sense of superiority and a hierarchical relationship with the others that the statement implies. While there are indeed ideologies that are built around disgust and hatred, as we are coming to re-recognize with increasing intensity, in most aspects of daily life, other people are not hell but "inconvenient, which is to say that they have to be dealt with" (Berlant, *Inconvenience* 2). This inconvenience of being in relations of attachment and friction with others is an inseparable part of co-existence. It forces us out of ourselves and into recognizing others and adjusting to them. This applies in all contexts, among strangers on a street or with our closest intimates in the confines of the home. The domestic fictions analyzed in this article model the presence and productivity of inconvenience as a mode of attachment. They allow us to ask "Why the things we look to for sustenance also induce defences against what we want from them, especially if one thing we want is to sustain life well while we are working out what to do with it" (Berlant, *Inconvenience* 6). The scenes of relationality at the level of the home point to broader perspectives of weathering the end of the future.

Berlant (*Inconvenience* 171) identifies "affirmative brokenness" that does not need to be an obstacle of living on. Similarly, Mara van der Lugt challenges the conventional equation of pessimism with defeatism and, instead, envisions a "hopeful pessimism," a hope "born of sheer uncertainty" as the future might bring both better and worse outcomes (xix). She stresses that even if we embrace pessimism, we remain moral agents because, despite accepting the darkness inherent in the time of rapid change, "there can still be this strange shattering openness, like a door cracked open, for the good to make its entry into life" (xxi). Pessimism does not eradicate hope; it creates a more informed hope. Lauren Berlant (*Cruel* 14) would seem to concur as she, too, believes that "optimism is, instead, a sense of negotiated sustenance that makes life bearable as it presents itself ambivalently, unevenly, incoherently." In an interview, she states that she takes people's attachments seriously, even if she would like to nudge them toward more wholesome ones that would make "it possible for us to think in more and different kinds of wants about how we relationally can move through life" (Berlant & Seitz n.p.).

The domestic novel might not at first sight appear as the most likely source of critique. Yet, as I have attempted to demonstrate above, it has juxtapolitical potential to invite lateral agency in a diminished world in which people live, "just not very well" (Berlant, *Cruel* 119). Overwhelmed life in such circumstances resembles "more desperate doggy paddling than the magnificent swim out to the horizon" (Berlant, *Cruel* 117). In such a context, affirmative images of possible futures fall flat. Hope can instead be found in measured pessimism that the two novels analyzed in the article fleshed out. Thereby they are able to, in the words of Caracciolo (189), to hold "a mirror up to our existential precarity in order to highlight what we may consider a way forward, an embrace of uncertainty where concern and hope coexist – uneasily, perhaps, but productively."

Note

1. Caracciolo (188–189) analyses the reviews of Offill's novel and finds the Goodreads reviews to lack opinions that embrace uncertainty, although the novel provides these reading potentials.

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